

Scoop: Brussels preps new rail deal

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SNEAK PEEK

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— Thousands of union workers from Germany's carmakers and parts suppliers are taking to the streets today to protest layoffs and factory closures.

— Europe is increasing protection for commercial shipping as security around the Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb Strait deteriorates.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

SCOOP — BRUSSELS PREPS AN ERTMS DEAL: The European Commission is preparing a new ERTMS Deal aimed at speeding up deployment of Europe's common rail signaling system, with plans to unveil it on Sept. 28, during Connecting Europe Days . An internal Commission document seen by POLITICO gives a first look at what Brussels is considering: a common technical blueprint, faster approvals and potentially preferential EU funding for projects that follow it.

ERTMS, in plain English: The European Rail Traffic Management System is the EU's effort to replace Europe's patchwork of national signaling and train-control systems with a common standard. In theory, that should make it easier for trains to cross borders without needing multiple national systems on board, while cutting costs and improving interoperability. In practice, deployment has been slow and fragmented.

The big idea: Brussels wants to move closer to genuinely standardized, "off-the-shelf" ERTMS equipment rather than today's mix of national specifications and project-by-project engineering. This blueprint would set out a more harmonized architecture for signaling and control-command systems, with the aim of cutting costs and speeding deployment.

Blueprint comes later: The blueprint itself does not exist yet. It is supposed to be developed through Europe's Rail Joint Undertaking, the EU-industry research and innovation partnership that brings together the Commission, rail companies, infrastructure managers, manufacturers and other sector players to develop common technical solutions for Europe's rail system. The idea is that the joint undertaking would produce a more harmonized plan for signaling and control-command systems, which could then become the reference point for future deployment.

And Brussels has a carrot: The idea under discussion is a Single European Railway Area label for projects that follow this blueprint. The SERA label could be linked to faster approval procedures and priority access to EU financing — effectively rewarding rail projects that align new investments with the Commission's preferred architecture.

But there's a problem: Much of Europe's future ERTMS deployment will take place on existing railways, where new systems have to coexist with legacy signaling and equipment already bought under current EU specifications. The debate is therefore not just about designing the future system, but about how to get there without forcing the premature replacement of functioning assets or disrupting projects already under way.

Don't punish early movers: Another concern is how the new architecture would treat investments that have already been made. The document raises questions over backward compatibility, transition periods and whether EU funding would cover adaptation costs if projects already in operation or under contract have to be modified to meet later blueprint requirements.

Questions over the label: It's also not clear who would award the SERA label, what evidence would be required, how long it would remain valid and what happens when the blueprint itself changes.

Faster approvals: Brussels is also considering ways to streamline trackside approvals, including grouping together projects using common engineering rules. The ambition is to cut the time and bureaucracy involved in getting ERTMS projects authorized rather than simply adding another layer of certification.

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CARS

AUTO WORKERS PROTEST IN GERMANY: Thousands of unionized workers from Germany's automakers and parts suppliers are taking to the streets today as part of a nationwide day of action to protest job cuts, factory closures and attempts by management to get employees to increase their weekly hours for the same pay.

Not our problem: Workers "will no longer pay the bill for management mistakes and the consequences of geopolitical conflicts," IG Metall said in a press release. The sector is struggling with high energy prices, increased tariffs and competition from Chinese rivals that have better electric vehicles, which the workers say is the fault of management which failed to adapt fast enough.

Backdrop: The action comes shortly after Volkswagen reached a deal with the union and its supervisory board to implement a cost-cutting plan that will cull 100,000 jobs and potentially close four German factories — a first in the automaker's 89-year history. The wave of layoffs across suppliers and manufacturers is helping fuel the rise of the far-right Alternative for Germany; exit polls indicated it had the lead in Sunday's state election in Mecklenburg-Western Pomerania.

More bad news: In a Friday news dump, Volkswagen announced a new profit warning, citing a sharp drop-off in sales in China, rising restructuring costs and a €6 billion writedown on the valuation of luxury subsidiary Porsche. The total negative impact on earnings could reach up to €10 billion, VW said.

Take action: The Chinese market — the world's largest — "has slumped by 20 percent. There are no signs of recovery on the horizon," COO Arne Antlitz said in a statement. "We cannot escape this trend. At the same time, Chinese manufacturers are flooding the European market with their low-cost exports." VW has called on the Commission to impose tariffs on Chinese plug-in hybrids, imports of which surged after the EU slapped duties on made-in-China EVs.

COMMISSION GETS FEEDBACK FOR CHINA ACTION: When he met with several European CEOs on Friday, EU trade boss Maroš Šefčovič was "in listening mode" on the threat posed by China's exports, two people familiar with the discussions told Jordyn and our colleague Koen Verhelst. "He spoke a bit about de-risking and the costs of that — or of doing nothing," one of the people said.

Strategic dialogue 2.0: The discussion mirrored the strategic dialogues that Commission President Ursula von der Leyen hosted last year with automotive executives. CEOs on Friday came with prepared talking points meant to inform the Commission's trade package on tackling competition from China.

Three points: Šefčovič let the CEOs do most of the talking but briefly outlined the three ways he hopes to counter China's export pressure. First is a potential diversification instrument, even though "he didn't say what he will do precisely," one of the people said. The second is adapting the EU's existing tools. The third is new free trade agreements with growing countries.

Need to act: The CEOs — ranging from automakers Renault and Volkswagen to chemicals giant BASF and auto supplier Schaeffler — all cited Chinese competition as a threat that needs to be urgently tackled. But there was little agreement as to how to do so without provoking retaliation from Beijing.

Careful now: "Lots of voices pointed to the risks of escalating countermeasures," one of the people who attended said. Both the squeeze on Dutch chip manufacturer Nexperia and the EU's reliance on Chinese critical raw materials — especially rare earth elements — came up several times.

Official terms: In a statement shared with media, the Commission stressed that "the cost of inaction is significant — risk to supply, loss of market position and erosion of our industrial base. We are therefore working towards a dedicated Diversification Package." It added that "we will soon be launching a public call for evidence, which will feed into the Commission's further work on this."

MARITIME

EUROPE STEPS UP RED SEA SHIPPING PROTECTION: Europe is increasing protection for commercial shipping as security around the Red Sea and the Bab el-Mandeb Strait deteriorates due to advances by Houthi rebels, with the EU's Operation Aspides raising the alert level of its vessels and Italy already escorting one of its merchant ships through the strait.

First Italian escort: On Friday, the Italian frigate Carlo Bergamini escorted an Italian commercial vessel through Bab el-Mandeb. The move came a day after Defense Minister Guido Crosetto said Italy was preparing to use its navy to guarantee the safe transit of Italian vessels rather than wait for the EU.

Aspides on alert: The EU's top diplomat Kaja Kallas said Friday that the EU mission had raised the alert level of its vessels while continuing escort duties. She called Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia "unacceptable" and said they were damaging the global economy, adding that maritime passage should

remain “unimpeded and toll-free.”

Why it matters: Crosetto warned Thursday that disruption to the region’s main shipping lanes would mean higher transport costs, delivery delays and eventually higher prices for businesses and consumers. He also highlighted the vulnerability of subsea infrastructure such as data cables and energy links.

The pressure on Aspides: The EU mission has been protecting merchant shipping in the Red Sea since 2024. According to figures cited by the EU’s diplomatic service, it has protected 720 cargo vessels, monitored 2,300 transits and rescued 128 seafarers over the past 29 months. The question now is whether worsening conditions around Bab el-Mandeb will force European governments to put more naval assets into the operation.

PIT STOPS

Klaus Zellmer, the CEO of Volkswagen subsidiary Škoda, will replace Håkan Samuelsson as CEO of Volvo Cars by Oct. 1, 2027, the automaker announced on Sunday .

Headlines

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By Helen Collis · Sept 21, 2026, 05:00 am Europe/Brussels CEST

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